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United States Patent	12411884
Kind Code	B2
Date of Patent	September 09, 2025
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Automatic lot classification

Abstract

Methods, systems, and media for lot classification are disclosed. In one example, a classification system for identifying lot listings receives a description for a listing in a publication system, identifies a string in the listing, identifies a quantity word or digit in the string, and converts an identified quantity word into digit form. A normalized string is tokenized to produce tokens, the tokenizing of the normalized string including splitting the normalized string into a series of substrings using a sequence of delimiters. For each substring, an additional split is performed by separating any digit from any other adjacent character, unless that character is another digit, and maintaining an internal character order of each split substring to produce a flattened list of tokenized tokens.

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Appl. No.:	18/641994
Filed:	April 22, 2024

Prior Publication Data

Document Identifier	Publication Date
US 20240273129 A1	Aug. 15, 2024

Related U.S. Application Data

continuation parent-doc US 17245406 20210430 US 12001471 child-doc US 18641994
continuation parent-doc US 15916207 20180308 US 11036780 child-doc US 17245406

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: **G06F16/00** (20190101); **G06F16/35** (20190101); **G06F16/358** (20250101); **G06N20/00** (20190101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC **G06F16/358** (20190101); **G06F16/35** (20190101); **G06N20/00** (20190101);

Field of Classification Search

CPC: G06F (16/358); G06F (16/35); G06N (20/00)

USPC: 707/737

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Background/Summary

CLAIM OF PRIORITY (1) This Application is a Continuation of U.S. application Ser. No. 17/245,406, filed Apr. 30, 2021, which is a Continuation of U.S. application Ser. No. 15/916,207, filed Mar. 8, 2018, now issued as U.S. Pat. No. 11,036,780, on Jun. 15, 2021, each of which is hereby incorporated by reference in its entirety.

TECHNICAL FIELD

(1) Embodiments of the present disclosure relate generally to data categorization. The disclosure is related more specifically to automatic lot classification.

BACKGROUND

(2) It is becoming increasingly common for online users to search for particular information, such as a product or service, in which they are interested using electronic search mechanisms, such as Internet-based search engines. The complex systems used by such electronic search mechanisms to process incoming product data from multiple merchants, and deliver that product data in the form of search results to millions of customers, seek to ensure that customers receive the best information available. In order to do this, the initial underlying data must first be obtained and will typically include information pertaining to millions of product or service offerings obtained from multiple sources. The information is often haphazard in format and content, and may even be inconsistent in some areas. Once obtained, the rough information is therefore usually categorized in order to, among other things, facilitate comparison of data and allow a clean, searchable presentation of information.

(3) While various and many attempts have been made to categorize products, very little attention has been given to classifying lots. One approach to categorizing product offerings has included a manual categorization approach. In the manual categorization approach, a human operator assigns product offerings to product categories. This manual method may in some circumstances be applicable for lot classification too. A problem with the manual categorization approach is that it is time and resource consuming, since a human operator typically seeks to assign each product offering to one or more particular product categories.

(4) Even a machine-learning system that attempts to learn a set of rules from supervised training cases faces significant challenge. For example, supervised techniques may require a large number of tagged training cases. Another example of a technical challenge that may exist is that such training cases cannot be generalized across different types of products. As a result, machine training techniques also face challenges in terms of scalability.

(5) The present inventors seek to address these and other technical problems, and seek to provide automatic lot classification systems, methods and media as technical solutions thereto, as described more fully below.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) Some embodiments of the present disclosure are illustrated by way of example and not limitation in the figures of the accompanying drawings, in which like reference numbers indicate similar elements.

(2) FIG. 1 is a block diagram illustrating a networked system, according to an example embodiment.

- (3) FIG. 2 is a block diagram showing architectural details of an example lot classification system, according to some example embodiments.
- (4) FIG. 3 is a block diagram illustrating a representative software architecture, which may be used in conjunction with various hardware architectures herein described.
- (5) FIG. 4 is a block diagram illustrating components of a machine, according to some example embodiments, able to read instructions from a machine-readable medium (e.g., a machine-readable storage medium) and perform any one or more of the methodologies discussed herein.
- (6) FIG. 5 is a flow chart of operations in a tokenization method, according to an example embodiment.
- (7) FIG. 6 is table showing aspects of feature vectors, according to example embodiments.
- (8) FIG. 7 is a table showing aspects of training examples, according to various embodiments.
- (9) FIG. 8 is a flow chart of operations in a classification method, according to an example embodiment.
- (10) FIG. 9 is a flow chart depicting operations in a lot classification algorithm, in accordance with an example embodiment.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(11) The description that follows includes illustrative systems, methods, techniques, instruction sequences, and computing machine program products that embody illustrative embodiments. In the following description, for purposes of explanation, numerous specific details are set forth in order to provide an understanding of various embodiments of the inventive subject matter. It will be evident, however, to those skilled in the art, that embodiments of the inventive subject matter can be practiced without these specific details. In general, well-known instruction instances, protocols, structures, and techniques have not been shown in detail. The present disclosure provides technical solutions for optimizing and improving lot classification. Systems, methods, and architectures for deployment optimization are disclosed herein.

(12) “CARRIER SIGNAL”, in this context, refers to any intangible medium that is capable of storing, encoding, or carrying instructions for execution by a machine, and includes digital or analog communications signals or other intangible media to facilitate communication of such instructions. Instructions may be transmitted or received over a network using a transmission medium via a network interface device and using any one of a number of well-known transfer protocols.

(13) “CLIENT DEVICE”, in this context, refers to any machine that interfaces with a communications network to obtain resources from one or more server systems or other client devices. A client device may be, but is not limited to, a mobile phone, desktop computer, laptop, portable digital assistant (PDA), smart phone, tablet, ultra-book, netbook, laptop, multi-processor system, microprocessor-based or programmable consumer electronics system, game console, set-top box, or any other communication device that a user may use to access a network.

(14) “COMMUNICATIONS NETWORK”, in this context, refers to one or more portions of a network that may be an ad hoc network, an intranet, an extranet, a virtual private network (VPN), a local area network (LAN), a wireless LAN (WLAN), a wide area network (WAN), a wireless WAN (WWAN), a metropolitan area network (MAN), the Internet, a portion of the Internet, a portion of the Public Switched Telephone Network (PSTN), a plain old telephone service (POTS) network, a cellular telephone network, a wireless network, a Wi-Fi® network, another type of network, or a combination of two or more such networks. For example, a network or a portion of a network may include a wireless or cellular network and the coupling of the client device to the network may be a Code Division Multiple Access (CDMA) connection, a Global System for Mobile communications (GSM) connection, or another type of cellular or wireless coupling. In this example, the coupling may implement any of a variety of types of data transfer technology, such as Single Carrier Radio Transmission Technology (1×RTT), Evolution-Data Optimized (EVDO) technology, General Packet Radio Service (GPRS) technology, Enhanced Data rates for GSM Evolution (EDGE)

technology, third Generation Partnership Project (3GPP) including 3G, fourth generation wireless (4G) networks, Universal Mobile Telecommunications System (UMTS), High Speed Packet Access (HSPA), Worldwide Interoperability for Microwave Access (WiMAX), Long Term Evolution (LTE) standard, others defined by various standard-setting organizations, other long-range protocols, or other data transfer technology.

(15) “COMPONENT”, in this context, refers to a device, a physical entity, or logic having boundaries defined by function, method, property, object or subroutine calls, branch points, application program interfaces (APIs), or other technologies that provide for the partitioning or modularization of particular processing or control functions. Components may be combined via their interfaces with other components to carry out a machine process. A component may be a packaged functional hardware unit designed for use with other components and a part of a program that usually performs a particular function of related functions. Components may constitute either software components (e.g., code embodied on a machine-readable medium) or hardware components.

(16) A “hardware component” is a tangible unit capable of performing certain operations and may be configured or arranged in a certain physical manner. In various example embodiments, one or more computer systems (e.g., a standalone computer system, a client computer system, or a server computer system) or one or more hardware components of a computer system (e.g., a processor or a group of processors) may be configured by software (e.g., an application or application portion) as a hardware component that operates to perform certain operations as described herein. A hardware component may also be implemented mechanically, electronically, or any suitable combination thereof. For example, a hardware component may include dedicated circuitry or logic that is permanently configured to perform certain operations. A hardware component may be a special-purpose processor, such as a field-programmable gate array (FPGA) or an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC). A hardware component may also include programmable logic or circuitry that is temporarily configured by software to perform certain operations. For example, a hardware component may include software executed by a general-purpose processor or other programmable processor. Once configured by such software, hardware components become specific machines (or specific components of a machine) uniquely tailored to perform the configured functions and are no longer general-purpose processors.

(17) It will be appreciated that the decision to implement a hardware component mechanically, in dedicated and permanently configured circuitry, or in temporarily configured circuitry (e.g., configured by software) may be driven by cost and time considerations. Accordingly, the phrase “hardware component” (or “hardware-implemented component”) should be understood to encompass a tangible entity, be that an entity that is physically constructed, permanently configured (e.g., hardwired), or temporarily configured (e.g., programmed) to operate in a certain manner or to perform certain operations described herein. Considering embodiments in which hardware components are temporarily configured (e.g., programmed), each of the hardware components need not be configured or instantiated at any one instance in time. For example, where a hardware component comprises a general-purpose processor configured by software to become a special-purpose processor, the general-purpose processor may be configured as respectively different special-purpose processors (e.g., comprising different hardware components) at different times. Software accordingly configures a particular processor or processors, for example, to constitute a particular hardware component at one instance of time and to constitute a different hardware component at a different instance of time. Hardware components can provide information to, and receive information from, other hardware components. Accordingly, the described hardware components may be regarded as being communicatively coupled. Where multiple hardware components exist contemporaneously, communications may be achieved through signal transmission (e.g., over appropriate circuits and buses) between or among two or more of the hardware components. In embodiments in which multiple hardware components are configured or

instantiated at different times, communications between such hardware components may be achieved, for example, through the storage and retrieval of information in memory structures to which the multiple hardware components have access. For example, one hardware component may perform an operation and store the output of that operation in a memory device to which it is communicatively coupled. A further hardware component may then, at a later time, access the memory device to retrieve and process the stored output. Hardware components may also initiate communications with input or output devices, and can operate on a resource (e.g., a collection of information).

(18) The various operations of example methods described herein may be performed, at least partially, by one or more processors that are temporarily configured (e.g., by software) or permanently configured to perform the relevant operations. Whether temporarily or permanently configured, such processors may constitute processor-implemented components that operate to perform one or more operations or functions described herein. As used herein, “processor-implemented component” refers to a hardware component implemented using one or more processors. Similarly, the methods described herein may be at least partially processor-implemented, with a particular processor or processors being an example of hardware. For example, at least some of the operations of a method may be performed by one or more processors or processor-implemented components. Moreover, the one or more processors may also operate to support performance of the relevant operations in a “cloud computing” environment or as a “software as a service” (SaaS). For example, at least some of the operations may be performed by a group of computers (as examples of machines including processors), with these operations being accessible via a network (e.g., the Internet) and via one or more appropriate interfaces (e.g., an API). The performance of certain of the operations may be distributed among the processors, not only residing within a single machine, but deployed across a number of machines. In some example embodiments, the processors or processor-implemented components may be located in a single geographic location (e.g., within a home environment, an office environment, or a server farm). In other example embodiments, the processors or processor-implemented components may be distributed across a number of geographic locations.

(19) “MACHINE-READABLE MEDIUM”, in this context, refers to a component, a device, or other tangible media able to store instructions and data temporarily or permanently, and may include, but not be limited to, random-access memory (RAM), read-only memory (ROM), buffer memory, flash memory, optical media, magnetic media, cache memory, other types of storage (e.g., erasable programmable read-only memory (EEPROM)), and/or any suitable combination thereof. The term “machine-readable medium” should be taken to include a single medium or multiple media (e.g., a centralized or distributed database, or associated caches and servers) able to store instructions. The term “machine-readable medium” shall also be taken to include any medium, or combination of multiple media, that is capable of storing instructions (e.g., code) for execution by a machine, such that the instructions, when executed by one or more processors of the machine, cause the machine to perform any one or more of the methodologies described herein. Accordingly, a “machine-readable medium” refers to a single storage apparatus or device, as well as “cloud-based” storage systems or storage networks that include multiple storage apparatus or devices. The term “machine-readable medium” excludes signals per se.

(20) “PROCESSOR”, in this context, refers to any circuit or virtual circuit (a physical circuit emulated by logic executing on an actual processor) that manipulates data values according to control signals (e.g., “commands”, “op codes”, “machine code”, etc.) and which produces corresponding output signals that are applied to operate a machine. A processor may, for example, be a central processing unit (CPU), a reduced instruction set computing (RISC) processor, a complex instruction set computing (CISC) processor, a graphics processing unit (GPU), a digital signal processor (DSP), an ASIC, a radio-frequency integrated circuit (RFIC), or any combination thereof. A processor may further be a multi-core processor having two or more independent

processors (sometimes referred to as “cores”) that may execute instructions contemporaneously.

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(22) A “lot” listing pertains to a group of identical items, such as batteries, as opposed to a “combination” or “bundle” listing, such as a camera and camera bag, for example. One conventional approach might be to classify a listing as a “lot” or “not-lot” based on various features using a machine learning classifier. Here, in one aspect, the problem is simplified and reduced to a classification of quantity words in a listing's title. In other words, a title without any quantity words is classified as “not lot”. A listing having a title including one or more quantity words may prima facie pertain to a lot and be classified on that basis accordingly. This may introduce significant errors since even a bundle listing may include more than one particular item in it. The title in the present disclosure is processed in accordance with the methods described herein and will be classified as a “lot” if at least one of the quantity words is predicted or assessed to pertain in fact to a lot; otherwise the listing will be classified as “not lot”.

(23) In some examples, the present disclosure relates to a system, method, and computer media for automatic lot classification based on the prima facie presence of quantity words appearing in a listing title. A description for a listing is received in a publication system. Various system components identify a string in the listing, identify a quantity word or digit in the string, and convert an identified quantity word into digit form. The string is normalized and includes only lowercase characters or digits. Further, the normalized string is tokenized to produce tokens. The tokenizing of the normalized string includes splitting the normalized string into a series of substrings using a sequence of delimiters. Additional splitting of the substrings is performed. Further, the disclosure describes assigning a probability to at least one token as being indicative of a lot quantity and classifying the listing as a lot listing based on the assigned probability. Based on the classification, a component in the system causes the display of the listing as a lot listing.

(24) With reference now to FIG. 1, an example embodiment of a high-level SaaS network architecture **100** is shown. A networked system **116** provides server-side functionality via a network **110** (e.g., the Internet or a WAN) to a client device **108**. A web client **102** and a programmatic client, in the example form of an application **104**, are hosted and execute on the client device **108**. The networked system **116** includes an application server **122**, which in turn hosts a publication system **106** that provides a number of functions and services to the application **104** that accesses the networked system **116**. The application **104** also provides a number of interfaces described herein, which present output of tracking and analysis operations to a user of the client device **108**. (25) The client device **108** enables a user to access and interact with the networked system **116**. For instance, the user provides input (e.g., touch screen input or alphanumeric input) to the client device **108**, and the input is communicated to the networked system **116** via the network **110**. In this instance, the networked system **116**, in response to receiving the input from the user, communicates information back to the client device **108** via the network **110** to be presented to the user.

(26) An application program interface (API) server **118** and a web server **120** are coupled, and provide programmatic and web interfaces respectively, to the application server **122**. The application server **122** is, in turn, shown to be coupled to a database server **124** that facilitates access to information storage repositories (e.g., a database **126**). In an example embodiment, the database **126** includes storage devices that store information accessed and generated by the publication system **106**. The database **126** may also store cloud-based or other data accessed or used by the application **104** executing on the client device **108**, or a third-party application **114**,

executing on a third-party server(s) **112**. The database **126** may be comprised of several remote or onsite databases, for example. Other configurations are possible.

(27) The third-party application **114**, executing on a third-party server(s) **112**, is shown as having programmatic access to the networked system **116** via the programmatic interface provided by the API server **118**. For example, the third-party application **114**, using information retrieved from the networked system **116**, may support one or more features or functions on a website hosted by a third party.

(28) Turning now specifically to the applications **104** hosted by the client device **108**, the web client **102** may access the various systems (e.g., publication system **106**) via the web interface supported by the web server **120**. Similarly, the application **104** (e.g., an “app”) accesses the various services and functions provided by the publication system **106** via the programmatic interface provided by the API server **118**. The application **104** may be, for example, an “app” executing on the client device **108**, such as an IOS™ or ANDROID™ OS application to enable a user to access and input data on the networked system **116** in an offline manner, and to perform batch-mode communications between the application **104** and the networked system **116**.

(29) Further, while the SaaS network architecture **100** shown in FIG. 1 employs a client-server architecture, the present disclosure is not limited to such an architecture, and could equally well find application in a distributed, or peer-to-peer, architecture system, for example. The publication system **106** could also be implemented as a standalone software program, which does not necessarily have networking capabilities.

(30) FIG. 2 is a block diagram showing architectural details of the publication system **106**, according to some example embodiments. This is a non-abstract system in the view, a power button is shown at **204**, and the publication system **106** includes computer processors and components, described further below. Hardwired connection pins may be seen at **205**, for example. The publication system **106** is specially-configured and technically improved to implement the methods described herein.

(31) More specifically, the publication system **106** is shown to include an interface component **201** by which the publication system **106** communicates (e.g., over a network **203**) with other systems within the SaaS network architecture **100**. The interface component **201** is collectively coupled to a lot classification component **206** that operates to perform, in conjunction with the illustrated components **208-216**, automatic lot classification in accordance with the methods described further below with reference to the accompanying drawings. The components **208-216** include a preprocessing component **208**, a normalization component **210**, a tokenization component **212**, a feature vector component **214**, and a training component **216**. The operations of these components are described further below.

(32) FIG. 3 is a block diagram illustrating an example software architecture **306**, which may be used in conjunction with various hardware architectures herein described. FIG. 3 is a non-limiting example of a software architecture **306** and it will be appreciated that many other architectures may be implemented to facilitate the functionality described herein.

(33) The software architecture **306** may execute on hardware such as a machine **400** of FIG. 4 that includes, among other things, processors **404**, memory/storage **406**, and I/O components **418**. A representative hardware layer **352** is illustrated and can represent, for example, the machine **400** of FIG. 4. The representative hardware layer **352** includes a processing unit **354** having associated executable instructions **304**. The executable instructions **304** represent the executable instructions **304** of the software architecture **306**, including implementation of the methods, components, and so forth described herein. The hardware layer **352** also includes memory and/or storage modules as memory/storage **356**, which also have the executable instructions **304**. The hardware layer **352** may also comprise other hardware **358**.

(34) In the example architecture of FIG. 3, the software architecture **306** may be conceptualized as a stack of layers where each layer provides particular functionality. For example, the software

architecture **306** may include layers such as an operating system **302**, libraries **320**, frameworks/middleware **318**, applications **316**, and a presentation layer **314**. Operationally, the applications **316** and/or other components within the layers may invoke application programming interface (API) API calls **308** through the software stack and receive messages **312** in response to the API calls **308**. The layers illustrated are representative in nature, and not all software architectures have all layers. For example, some mobile or special-purpose operating systems may not provide a frameworks/middleware **318**, while others may provide such a layer. Other software architectures may include additional or different layers.

(35) The operating system **302** may manage hardware resources and provide common services. The operating system **302** may include, for example, a kernel **322**, services **324**, and drivers **326**. The kernel **322** may act as an abstraction layer between the hardware and the other software layers. For example, the kernel **322** may be responsible for memory management, processor management (e.g., scheduling), component management, networking, security settings, and so on. The services **324** may provide other common services for the other software layers. The drivers **326** are responsible for controlling or interfacing with the underlying hardware. For instance, the drivers **326** include display drivers, camera drivers, Bluetooth® drivers, flash memory drivers, serial communication drivers (e.g., Universal Serial Bus (USB) drivers), Wi-Fi® drivers, audio drivers, power management drivers, and so forth depending on the hardware configuration.

(36) The libraries **320** provide a common infrastructure that is used by the applications **316** and/or other components and/or layers. The libraries **320** provide functionality that allows other software components to perform tasks in an easier fashion than by interfacing directly with the underlying operating system **302** functionality (e.g., kernel **322**, services **324**, and/or drivers **326**). The libraries **320** may include system libraries **344** (e.g., C standard library) that may provide functions such as memory allocation functions, string manipulation functions, mathematical functions, and the like. In addition, the libraries **320** may include API libraries **346** such as media libraries (e.g., libraries to support presentation and manipulation of various media formats such as MPEG4, H.264, MP3, AAC, AMR, JPG, and PNG), graphics libraries (e.g., an OpenGL framework that may be used to render 2D and 3D graphic content on a display), database libraries (e.g., SQLite that may provide various relational database functions), web libraries (e.g., WebKit that may provide web browsing functionality), and the like. The libraries **320** may also include a wide variety of other libraries **348** to provide many other APIs to the applications **316** and other software components or modules.

(37) The frameworks/middleware **318** (also sometimes referred to as middleware) provide a higher-level common infrastructure that may be used by the applications **316** and/or other software components/modules. For example, the frameworks/middleware **318** may provide various graphic user interface (GUI) functions **342**, high-level resource management, high-level location services, and so forth. The frameworks/middleware **318** may provide a broad spectrum of other APIs that may be utilized by the applications **316** and/or other software components/modules, some of which may be specific to a particular operating system **302** or platform.

(38) The applications **316** include built-in applications **338** and/or third-party applications **340**. Examples of representative built-in applications **338** may include, but are not limited to, a contacts application, a browser application, a book reader application, a location application, a media application, a messaging application, and/or a game application. The third-party applications **340** may include any application developed using the ANDROID™ or IOS™ software development kit (SDK) by an entity other than the vendor of the particular platform, and may be mobile software running on a mobile operating system such as IOS™, ANDROID™, WINDOWS® Phone, or other mobile operating systems. The third-party applications **340** may invoke the API calls **308** provided by the mobile operating system (such as the operating system **302**) to facilitate functionality described herein.

(39) The applications **316** may use built-in operating system functions (e.g., kernel **322**, services **324**, and/or drivers **326**), libraries **320**, and frameworks/middleware **318** to create user interfaces to

interact with users of the system. Alternatively, or additionally, in some systems, interactions with a user may occur through a presentation layer, such as the presentation layer **314**. In these systems, the application/component “logic” can be separated from the aspects of the application/component that interact with a user.

(40) Some software architectures use virtual machines. In the example of FIG. **3**, this is illustrated by a virtual machine **310**. The virtual machine **310** creates a software environment where applications/components can execute as if they were executing on a hardware machine (such as the machine **400** of FIG. **4**, for example). The virtual machine **310** is hosted by a host operating system (operating system **302** in FIG. **3**) and typically, although not always, has a virtual machine monitor **360**, which manages the operation of the virtual machine **310** as well as the interface with the host operating system (i.e., operating system **302**). A software architecture executes within the virtual machine **310**, such as an operating system (OS) **336**, libraries **334**, frameworks **332**, applications **330**, and/or a presentation layer **328**. These layers of software architecture executing within the virtual machine **310** can be the same as corresponding layers previously described or may be different.

(41) FIG. **4** is a block diagram illustrating components of a machine **400**, according to some example embodiments, able to read instructions **304** from a machine-readable medium (e.g., a machine-readable storage medium) and perform any one or more of the methodologies discussed herein. Specifically, FIG. **4** shows a diagrammatic representation of the machine **400** in the example form of a computer system, within which instructions **410** (e.g., software, a program, an application **316**, an applet, an app, or other executable code) for causing the machine **400** to perform any one or more of the methodologies discussed herein, may be executed. As such, the instructions **410** may be used to implement modules or components described herein. The instructions **410** transform the general, non-programmed machine into a particular machine **400** programmed to carry out the described and illustrated functions in the manner described. In alternative embodiments, the machine **400** operates as a standalone device or may be coupled (e.g., networked) to other machines. In a networked deployment, the machine **400** may operate in the capacity of a server machine or a client machine in a server-client network environment, or as a peer machine in a peer-to-peer (or distributed) network environment. The machine **400** may comprise, but not be limited to, a server computer, a client computer, a personal computer (PC), a tablet computer, a laptop computer, a netbook, a set-top box (STB), a PDA, an entertainment media system, a cellular telephone, a smart phone, a mobile device, a wearable device (e.g., a smart watch), a smart home device (e.g., a smart appliance), other smart devices, a web appliance, a network router, a network switch, a network bridge, or any machine capable of executing the instructions **410**, sequentially or otherwise, that specify actions to be taken by the machine **400**. Further, while only a single machine **400** is illustrated, the term “machine” shall also be taken to include a collection of machines that individually or jointly execute the instructions **410** to perform any one or more of the methodologies discussed herein.

(42) The machine **400** may include processors **404**, memory/storage **406**, and I/O components **418**, which may be configured to communicate with each other such as via a bus **402**. The memory/storage **406** may include a memory **414**, such as a main memory, or other memory storage, and a storage unit **416**, both accessible to the processors **404** such as via the bus **402**. The storage unit **416** and memory **414** store the instructions **410** embodying any one or more of the methodologies or functions described herein. The instructions **410** may also reside, completely or partially, within the memory **414**, within the storage unit **416**, within at least one of the processors **404** (e.g., within the processor's cache memory), or any suitable combination thereof, during execution thereof by the machine **400**. Accordingly, the memory **414**, the storage unit **416**, and the memory of the processors **404** are examples of machine-readable media.

(43) The I/O components **418** may include a wide variety of components to receive input, provide output, produce output, transmit information, exchange information, capture measurements, and so

on. The specific I/O components **418** that are included in a particular machine **400** will depend on the type of machine. For example, portable machines such as mobile phones will likely include a touch input device or other such input mechanisms, while a headless server machine will likely not include such a touch input device. It will be appreciated that the I/O components **418** may include many other components that are not shown in FIG. 4. The I/O components **418** are grouped according to functionality merely for simplifying the following discussion and the grouping is in no way limiting. In various example embodiments, the I/O components **418** may include output components **426** and input components **428**. The output components **426** may include visual components (e.g., a display such as a plasma display panel (PDP), a light emitting diode (LED) display, a liquid crystal display (LCD), a projector, or a cathode ray tube (CRT)), acoustic components (e.g., speakers), haptic components (e.g., a vibratory motor, resistance mechanisms), other signal generators, and so forth. The input components **428** may include alphanumeric input components (e.g., a keyboard, a touch screen configured to receive alphanumeric input, a photo-optical keyboard, or other alphanumeric input components), point-based input components (e.g., a mouse, a touchpad, a trackball, a joystick, a motion sensor, or other pointing instruments), tactile input components (e.g., a physical button, a touch screen that provides location and/or force of touches or touch gestures, or other tactile input components), audio input components (e.g., a microphone), and the like.

(44) In further example embodiments, the I/O components **418** may include biometric components **430**, motion components **434**, environment components **436**, or position components **438** among a wide array of other components. For example, the biometric components **430** may include components to detect expressions (e.g., hand expressions, facial expressions, vocal expressions, body gestures, or eye tracking), measure bio signals (e.g., blood pressure, heart rate, body temperature, perspiration, or brain waves), identify a person (e.g., voice identification, retinal identification, facial identification, fingerprint identification, or electroencephalogram-based identification), and the like. The motion components **434** may include acceleration sensor components (e.g., accelerometer), gravitation sensor components, rotation sensor components (e.g., gyroscope), and so forth. The environment components **436** may include, for example, illumination sensor components (e.g., photometer), temperature sensor components (e.g., one or more thermometers that detect ambient temperature), humidity sensor components, pressure sensor components (e.g., barometer), acoustic sensor components (e.g., one or more microphones that detect background noise), proximity sensor components (e.g., infrared sensors that detect nearby objects), gas sensors (e.g., gas detection sensors to detect concentrations of hazardous gases for safety or to measure pollutants in the atmosphere), or other components that may provide indications, measurements, or signals corresponding to a surrounding physical environment. The position components **438** may include location sensor components (e.g., a Global Position System (GPS) receiver component), altitude sensor components (e.g., altimeters or barometers that detect air pressure from which altitude may be derived), orientation sensor components (e.g., magnetometers), and the like.

(45) Communication may be implemented using a wide variety of technologies. The I/O components **418** may include communication components **440** operable to couple the machine **400** to a network **432** or devices **420** via a coupling **424** and a coupling **422** respectively. For example, the communication components **440** may include a network interface component or another suitable device to interface with the network **432**. In further examples, the communication components **440** may include wired communication components, wireless communication components, cellular communication components, near field communication (NFC) components, Bluetooth® components (e.g., Bluetooth® Low Energy), Wi-Fi® components, and other communication components to provide communication via other modalities. The devices **420** may be another machine or any of a wide variety of peripheral devices (e.g., a peripheral device coupled via a USB).

(46) Moreover, the communication components **440** may detect identifiers or include components operable to detect identifiers. For example, the communication components **440** may include radio frequency identification (RFID) tag reader components, NFC smart tag detection components, optical reader components (e.g., an optical sensor to detect one-dimensional bar codes such as Universal Product Code (UPC) bar code, multi-dimensional bar codes such as Quick Response (QR) code, Aztec code, Data Matrix, Dataglyph, MaxiCode, PDF417, Ultra Code, UCC RSS-2D bar code, and other optical codes), or acoustic detection components (e.g., microphones to identify tagged audio signals). In addition, a variety of information may be derived via the communication components **440**, such as location via Internet Protocol (IP) geolocation, location via Wi-Fi® signal triangulation, location via detecting an NFC beacon signal that may indicate a particular location, and so forth.

(47) Referring back to FIG. 2, it will be recalled that in some examples the publication system **106** comprises inter alia components **208-216**. Their respective operations are now described. The preprocessing component **208** receives as input **207** a raw item title in a given listing. The input item title is first normalized and then tokenized. The listing may be a lot listing, or it may not. The aim is to classify the listing accurately without classification errors of the type inherent in manual or conventional machine learning as discussed above, or at least minimize them. The preprocessing component **208** and the normalization component **210** act alone or in conjunction with each other to normalize the raw item title. The title is converted to lowercase and then any letter with an accent mark is replaced by its non-accented form. Tokens which are quantity (or number) words are converted to their numerical form. The output **209** from the normalization component **210** includes a normalized title string. An example normalization operation may include, as example input, “Vier Stück Apple iPhone 5s”, and as example output, “4 stuck apple iphone 5s”.

(48) The normalized output **209** is received as input to the tokenization component **212** which operates to convert the input normalized title string into a list of tokenized strings (“tokens”). With reference to FIG. 5, an example tokenization method **500** may include one or more of the following operations: at operation **502**, splitting the normalized title string into a list of substrings using any sequence of whitespace characters as delimiter (i.e., space or tab characters); at operation **504**, for each resulting substring, performing an additional split on the substring by separating any digit character from any other adjacent character unless that character is another digit; at operation **506**, maintaining the internal order of the split string's substrings; and, at operation **508**, returning a flattened list of tokenized tokens in an output **211**.

(49) An example tokenization method may include: as example input **209** into the tokenization component **212** “4 stuck apple iphone 5s”, and as example output **211** from the tokenization component **212** [“4”, “stuck”, “apple”, “iphone”, “5s”], or [“4”, “stuck”, “apple”, “iphone”, [“5”, “s”]], or [“4”, “stuck”, “apple”, “iphone”, “5”, “s”].

(50) With reference now to the feature vector component **214**, this component may work in conjunction with the other components **206-212** and **216**, or independently therefrom to assist in computing one or more feature vectors as output **213**. In order to train a model with a labeled example of a lot listing or to classify a new lot listing example with the trained model, a numerical vector is computed for that example. This vector serves as the actual input to the model itself and each of its elements represents a distinct feature which is computed using a specific method. In some examples, a vector includes features representing each quantity word that may distinguish between a lot word and a non-lot word. For example, a “token after” is a word after the quantity word and it may serve to distinguish between the two classes (e.g., if it is “package” the quantity word may more likely be a lot).

(51) In some examples, a feature vector (whether it be for training or inference) is computed for each candidate quantity word. Meaning, a model is not computed on quantity words only because it is not known that words are quantities in advance—not all numerical tokens represent quantities. Each numerical token has the potential to become a listing's so-called “quantity word” (lot size).

Therefore each feature (e.g., “token after”) and its value (e.g., “package”) aims to describe and contextualize a numerical token (e.g., “package” is the token after “10”), thus providing information for the model to estimate that candidate's likelihood of being a quantity word.

(52) Example feature methods are set forth in the table illustrated in FIG. 6. The table includes an input and output for each feature method, and includes explanatory comments for some of the feature elements.

(53) The training component **216** receives as input the computed feature vector output **213** by the feature vector component **214**. In some examples, a model per meta category is trained by using a training set of listing titles for items which are listed under that category. These items may be historical or live items.

(54) Training items are collected by filtering those which have a value in a field LOT_SIZE which is greater than 1. In some examples, this is a field that is optionally indicated by a seller of the item at a time of listing. If a LOT_SIZE value is not indicated by the seller, it has a default value of 1 and therefore such items are ignored and excluded from the training set. In order to train the model, only the raw title string and the LOT_SIZE value are extracted from the listing title and constitute an entry in the training set.

(55) Labels are assigned to the training examples comprising the training set before training a supervised machine learning model. In one general example addressing the lot classification problem, positive labels indicate that an item (i.e., the listing title) pertains to a “lot” item while negative labels indicate it is not a “lot”. More specifically in one implementation, numerical tokens in the item listing title are assigned labels testifying to whether or not the token indicates a lot size or a quantity of that item described by the title.

(56) Once the training set of item listing titles (also termed “training examples”) and corresponding LOT_SIZE values have been assembled, the process of labeling the training data begins. Instead of labeling an item listing title, labels are given to only the numerical (positive natural number) tokens in a given item listing title. Thus, in one embodiment, the preprocessing step described above is executed on raw training item titles. As a result, numerical tokens which surface serve as the actual training examples fed to the model training process. Multiple training examples can sprout from the same item. A single training example (numerical token) can either have a positive or negative label in some examples. A positive label (“POS”) may be assigned to a training example if the item from which it came had a LOT_SIZE value equal to the token represented by that example. Otherwise, a negative label (“NEG”) is assigned to the example. Aspects of an example embodiment of a training example are shown in FIG. 7.

(57) In some examples, the training model includes a Logistic Regression binary classifier. The model learns what characteristics (features) of “quantity” numerical tokens contribute to whether or not an item listing title (from which the token came from) can be classified as a “lot” listing using the label as the identifier. This learning method learns a weight for each of the features, which serve as the basis of the calculation of the answers (or predictions) calculated and output by the trained model.

(58) Thus, in one example, a classification system comprises at least one processor and a memory storing instructions that, when executed by the at least one processor, cause the classification system to perform operations comprising, at least: receiving a description for a listing in a publication system; identifying a string in the listing, identifying a quantity word or digit in the string, converting an identified quantity word into digit form, and normalizing the string to produce a normalized string including only lowercase characters or digits; tokenizing the normalized string to produce tokens, the tokenizing of the normalized string including splitting the normalized string into a series of substrings using a sequence of delimiters, at least one of the substrings including a lowercase character or digit; for each substring, performing an additional split on the substring by separating any digit from any other adjacent character, unless that character is another digit, and maintaining the internal character order of each split substring to produce a flattened list of

tokenized tokens; based on a trained model, assigning a probability to at least one token as being indicative of a lot quantity; classifying the listing as a lot listing based on the assigned probability; and based on the classification, causing the display of the listing as a lot listing.

(59) In some examples, identifying a string in the listing includes identifying the string in a title of the listing, and the sequence of delimiters includes white space delimiters. The classification system may further comprise a feature vector component for creating a feature vector for training the trained model, the feature vector component receiving as input a tokenized listing title including a position of a numerical token in a tokenized listing title and wherein, in relation to the position of the numerical token, the feature vector includes one or more of: a token after vector, a bigram after vector, a token before vector, a bigram before vector, a unit of measure vector, a token position ratio, and a token is divisible by k vector.

(60) In some examples, the classification system further comprises a training component receiving as input the feature vector computed by the feature vector component, and wherein a training model per meta category is trained by the training component using a training set of listing titles for items which are listed under that meta category. In some examples, only a raw listing title string and an assigned lot size value are extracted from the listing title and are included as an entry in a training set for the trained model.

(61) The present disclosure also includes example methods. In one example, and with reference to FIG. 8, a classification method **800** includes operations such as, at operation **802**, receiving a description for a listing in a publication system; at operation **804**, identifying a string in the listing, identifying a quantity word or digit in the string, converting an identified quantity word into digit form, and normalizing the string to produce a normalized string including only lowercase characters or digits; at operation **806**, tokenizing the normalized string to produce tokens, the tokenizing of the normalized string including splitting the normalized string into a series of substrings using a sequence of delimiters, at least one of the substrings including a lowercase character or digit; at operation **808**, for each substring, performing an additional split on the substring by separating any digit from any other adjacent character, unless that character is another digit, and maintaining the internal character order of each split substring to produce a flattened list of tokenized tokens; at operation **810**, based on a trained model, assigning a probability to at least one token as being indicative of a lot quantity; at operation **812**, classifying the listing as a lot listing based on the assigned probability; and, at operation **814**, based on the classification, causing the display of the listing as a lot listing.

(62) Identifying a string in the listing may include identifying the string in a title of the listing, and the sequence of delimiters may include white space delimiters.

(63) The classification method may further comprise creating a feature vector for training the trained model by receiving a tokenized listing title including a position of a numerical token in a tokenized listing title, and wherein, in relation to the position of the numerical token, the feature vector includes one or more of: a token after vector, a bigram after vector, a token before vector, a bigram before vector, a unit of measure vector, a token position ratio, and a token is divisible by k vector.

(64) In some examples, the classification method further comprises receiving the feature vector as input into a training component, and training a training model for a meta category using the training component and a training set of listing titles for items which are listed under that meta category.

(65) In some examples, the classification method further comprises extracting only a raw listing title string and an assigned lot size value from the listing title and including them as an entry in a training set for the trained model.

(66) In another embodiment, with reference to FIG. 9, a lot classification algorithm **900** includes operations such as, at operation **902**, preprocessing a listing title using one or more of the preprocessing methods described above; at operation **904**, identifying positive natural numerical

tokens in the listing title which are greater than 1; at operation **906**, if there are no numerical tokens, then IS_LOT="NOT_LOT"; at operation **908**, for each numerical token in item title: at operation **910**, compute a feature vector for the token; at operation **912**, execute a meta category model on the feature vector input; at operation **914**, if the model's prediction answer is 0, then continue to the next numerical token (IS_LOT="NOT_LOT"); else (if 1), at operation **916**, reserve the token as a candidate for a final selection process for the training model (candidate's IS_LOT="LOT", LOT_SIZE=token, SCORE=model's confidence). The operations **910-916** may be sub-operations of operation **908**. At operation **918**, if no numerical tokens are reserved as candidates, then IS_LOT="NOT_LOT"; else, at operation **920**, select the candidate token with the highest SCORE. Finally, at operation **922**, IS_LOT="LOT", LOT_SIZE=token.

(67) In some examples, a non-transitory machine-readable medium includes instructions **410** that, when read by a machine **400**, cause the machine **400** to perform operations comprising at least the non-limiting example operations summarized above.

(68) Although the subject matter has been described with reference to some specific example embodiments, it will be evident that various modifications and changes may be made to these embodiments without departing from the broader spirit and scope of the disclosed subject matter. Accordingly, the specification and drawings are to be regarded in an illustrative rather than a restrictive sense. The accompanying drawings that form a part hereof show by way of illustration, and not of limitation, specific embodiments in which the subject matter may be practiced. The embodiments illustrated are described in sufficient detail to enable those skilled in the art to practice the teachings disclosed herein. Other embodiments may be utilized and derived therefrom, such that structural and logical substitutions and changes may be made without departing from the scope of this disclosure. This Description, therefore, is not to be taken in a limiting sense, and the scope of various embodiments is defined only by any appended claims, along with the full range of equivalents to which such claims are entitled.

(69) Such embodiments of the inventive subject matter may be referred to herein, individually and/or collectively, by the term "invention" merely for convenience and without intending to voluntarily limit the scope of this application to any single invention or inventive concept if more than one is in fact disclosed. Thus, although specific embodiments have been illustrated and described herein, it should be appreciated that any arrangement calculated to achieve the same purpose may be substituted for the specific embodiments shown. This disclosure is intended to cover any and all adaptations or variations of various embodiments. Combinations of the above embodiments, and other embodiments not specifically described herein, will be apparent to those of skill in the art upon reviewing the above description.

Claims

1. A computer implemented tokenization method comprising: receiving a normalized title string; tokenizing the normalized title string by: splitting, by one or more processors, the normalized title string into a plurality of substrings using a sequence of whitespaces as a delimiter; for each substring of the plurality of substrings, performing an additional split in each substring of the plurality of substrings where a digit character is separated from a non-digit character to create split substrings for each of the substrings of the plurality of substrings to create a plurality of tokens for the normalized title string, an individual substring of the plurality of substrings comprising the digit character adjacent to the non-digit character without the delimiter between the digit character and the non-digit character, the performing the additional split comprising processing the individual substring by a machine learning model to split the digit character from the non-digit character to create the two tokens of the plurality of tokens; and maintaining an order of the split substrings; and creating a flattened list of the plurality of tokens for the normalized title string.

2. The tokenization method of claim 1, wherein the normalized title string is normalized from a

- non-normalized text string and the method includes normalizing the non-normalized text string by: converting non-digit characters that are uppercase non-digit characters to lowercase non-digit characters; determining that one of the non-digit characters of the non-normalized text string corresponds to quantity words; and converting the non-digit characters that correspond to quantity words to digit characters.
3. The tokenization method of claim 2, wherein others of the non-digit characters of the non-normalized text string correspond to an item title in a listing for an item.
4. The tokenization method of claim 1, further comprising assigning a probability to a token of the plurality of tokens, the probability being indicative of a lot quantity, the machine learning model trained by performing training operations comprising: receiving a training set of listing titles having assigned lot size values greater than one; for each listing title in the training set: preprocessing the listing title to identify numerical tokens; computing a feature vector for each numerical token; assigning a positive label to the numerical token if the numerical token equals the assigned lot size value for the listing title; assigning a negative label to the numerical token if the numerical token does not equal the assigned lot size value for the listing title; and training a logistic regression binary classifier using the computed feature vectors and assigned labels to generate a trained model for identifying lot quantities.
5. The tokenization method of claim 4, wherein the feature vector includes one or more of: a token after vector indicating a token following the numerical token, a bigram after vector, a token before vector indicating a token preceding the numerical token, a bigram before vector, a unit of measure vector, a token position ratio indicating a ratio of the numerical token's position to a length of the listing title, and a token divisibility vector, and wherein the probability is based on a position of the token in the normalized title string and the method further comprises classifying a listing associated with the normalized title string as a lot listing based on the probability.
6. The tokenization method of claim 4, wherein the order is an internalized order of the split substrings.
7. The tokenization method of claim 1, wherein performing the additional split in each substring of the plurality of substrings comprises separating a character from an adjacent character based on a difference between the character and the adjacent character.
8. A system, comprising: at least one processor; and a memory device storing instructions which, when executed by the at least one processor, causes the system to perform operations comprising: receiving a normalized title string; tokenizing the normalized title string by: splitting the normalized title string into a plurality of substrings using a sequence of whitespaces as a delimiter; for each substring of the plurality of substrings, performing an additional split in each substring of the plurality of substrings where a digit character is separated from a non-digit character to create split substrings for each of the substrings of the plurality of substrings to create a plurality of tokens for the normalized title string, an individual substring of the plurality of substrings comprising the digit character adjacent to the non-digit character without the delimiter between the digit character and the non-digit character, the performing the additional split comprising processing the individual substring by a machine learning model to split the digit character from the non-digit character to create the two tokens of the plurality of tokens; and maintaining an order of the split substrings; and creating a flattened list of the plurality of tokens for the normalized title string.
9. The system of claim 8, wherein the normalized title string is normalized from a non-normalized text string and the processor, when executing the instructions, causes the system to perform operations comprising: converting non-digit characters that are uppercase non-digit characters to lowercase non-digit characters; determining that one of the non-digit characters of the non-normalized text string corresponds to quantity words; and converting the non-digit characters that correspond to quantity words to digit characters.
10. The system of claim 9, wherein others of the non-digit characters of the non-normalized text string correspond to an item title in a listing for an item.

11. The system of claim 8, the processor, when executing the instructions, causes the system to perform operations comprising assigning a probability to a token of the plurality of tokens, the probability being indicative of a lot quantity.
 12. The system of claim 11, wherein the probability is based on a position of the token in the normalized title string and the processor, when executing the instructions, causes the system to perform operations comprising classifying a listing associated with the normalized title string as a lot listing based on the probability.
 13. The system of claim 11, wherein the order is an internalized order of the split substrings.
 14. The system of claim 8, wherein when performing the additional split in each substring of the plurality of substrings the processor, when executing the instructions, causes the system to perform operations comprising separating a character from an adjacent character based on a difference between the character and the adjacent character.
 15. A non-transitory computer-readable medium comprising instructions which, when read by a machine, cause the machine to perform operations comprising: receiving a normalized title string; tokenizing the normalized title string by: splitting the normalized title string into a plurality of substrings using a sequence of whitespaces as a delimiter; for each substring of the plurality of substrings, performing an additional split in each substring of the plurality of substrings where a digit character is separated from a non-digit character to create split substrings for each of the substrings of the plurality of substrings to create a plurality of tokens for the normalized title string, an individual substring of the plurality of substrings comprising the digit character adjacent to the non-digit character without the delimiter between the digit character and the non-digit character, the performing the additional split comprising processing the individual substring by a machine learning model to split the digit character from the non-digit character to create the two tokens of the plurality of tokens; and maintaining an order of the split substrings; and creating a flattened list of the plurality of tokens for the normalized title string.
 16. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, wherein the normalized title string is normalized from a non-normalized text string and the instructions further cause the machine to perform operations comprising: converting non-digit characters that are uppercase non-digit characters to lowercase non-digit characters; determining that one of the non-digit characters of the non-normalized text string corresponds to quantity words; and converting the non-digit characters that correspond to quantity words to digit characters, wherein others of the non-digit characters of the non-normalized text string correspond to an item title in a listing for an item.
 17. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, the instructions further cause the machine to perform operations comprising assigning a probability to a token of the plurality of tokens, the probability being indicative of a lot quantity.
 18. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 17, wherein the probability is based on a position of the token in the normalized title string and the instructions further cause the machine to perform operations comprising classifying a listing associated with the normalized title string as a lot listing based on the probability.
 19. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 17, wherein the order is an internalized order of the split substrings.
 20. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, wherein when performing the additional split in each substring of the plurality of substrings the instructions further cause the machine to perform operations comprising separating a character from an adjacent character based on a difference between the character and the adjacent character.
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